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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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CHAPTER IX THE RITUAL OF CHILDBIRTH

We are Kado, our origin was in Bornu; this is what we do when we have children. It is a little different from the Fulani custom—their women go to their father's compound to have their children.

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When you become pregnant you stay in your husband's compound. When you have brought forth your child in your husband's home, and he has been given his name seven days later, on the eighth day they take you to your parents' home. There is feasting and drumming all night, your husband remains hidden. In the morning the grandmother of the child, on the father's or the mother's side, washes the babe and ties him on her back; that is the grandmother who is the midwife. By then the child's mother is able to wash herself, but for the first seven days her cross-cousin came and did it for her, while her mother washed the baby.

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But before the child is born, after you have been five months pregnant, you no longer sleep with your husband. You do all the ordinary work until the seventh month, then you do a little less. Round about the seventh month, or earlier, the husband begins to cut down wood in the bush and collect it, he and his younger brother and his joking relations. If they won't help him, his mother will. They collect a large amount of wood. Then at the eighth month the husband's mother buys ginger, potash, cloves, peppers and all kinds of hot

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